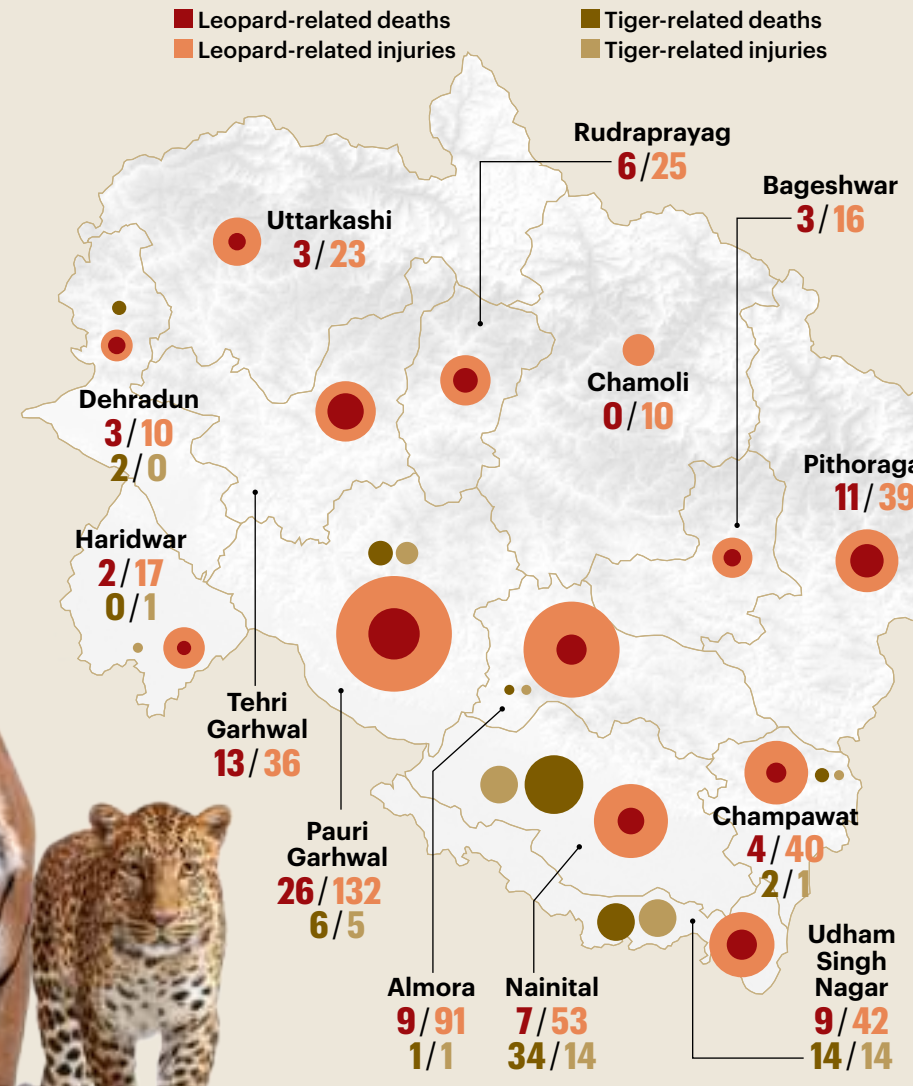
HUMAN DEATHS AND INJURIES DUE TO TIGERS AND LEOPARDS (DISTRICT-WISE, 2021-25)



Source: Uttarakhand Forest Department

of carrying capacity—the number of animals that a habitat can sustain during its least productive period based on food, water and space. "In some areas, we may be approaching that limit," he says. Invasive weeds are reducing palatable grasses for herbivores, weakening prey bases. Detailed carrying capacity assessments have begun only recently in the Corbett and Rajaji National Parks. Roads, canals and power lines are also fragmenting forests and disrupting animal movement. Together, these factors are exacerbating encounters between humans and animals and contributing to the rising number of deaths.

MANAGING CONFLICT

In many parts of the state's Garhwal and Kumaon divisions, authorities have laid cages in village after village after attacks on children and the elderly. In some areas, informal night patrols have begun. In parts of Champawat and Pithoragarh districts, teachers escort children to school, and attendance has dipped. "The administration at times responds by shutting schools or advising people to move in groups. But these are short-term measures. We need something more durable," says Jayvardhan Kanpal, zila panchayat member, Rudraprayag. In rural parts, women are often the ones who venture out to collect fodder and fuelwood, increasing their exposure to risk; forest officials advise preventive steps. Among their recommendations: clear shrubs near homes, improve lighting, secure livestock at night and avoid entering forests alone.

Ramnagar residents staged protests following a series of deaths. "We demanded that the administration either capture the tiger or shoot it," says former block pramukh Negi. "A tiger was captured. But people have seen four or five different tigers moving in the area." But, as Melkani says, "Eliminating wildlife cannot be the answer. We need preventive measures." The existing measures, he argues, reduce surprise encounters but do not offer absolute protection.

Pandey stresses coexistence as the only sustainable approach. The department has launched awareness initiatives, formed 94 community-based quick response teams across 32 forest divisions, and screened *Guldar ki Dagdiya*, a short film on the importance of coexistence, in schools. Whistles have been distributed to children to create noise in vulnerable stretches. Yet operational gaps remain. The Uttarakhand forest department has 55 trapping cages for leopards and 24 for tigers across the state. In most cases, captured animals are released back into forests unless they are involved in repeated incidents. Moreover, uncertainty often persists over whether the attacker was a leopard or a tiger, as trapped animals are not tested against biological samples from victims in all cases.

At the national level, wildlife concerns need to be integrated into development planning, securing corridors, creating underpasses, reducing forest dependence in hotspots, improving compensation systems, and promoting preventive measures such as solar fencing and better waste management. Also needed is strengthening of rapid response teams and investing in long-term ecological research.

Only then will the balance of nature be restored and man and animal can co-exist in harmony. ■

Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**